

# Rushdie & Roy: guided exercises

*Private practice for Hana and Aiden*

Use this version before the plain worksheet. Each page explains the literary move, shows one model answer, and then leaves space for a new answer. The aim is to borrow the method, not the exact words.

Rule: use normal English words. Do not copy the source fragment or the model answer.

## 1. Rushdie: pressure from the past

### *"handcuffed to history"*

Salman Rushdie, *Midnight's Children* (1981)

**Plain English**

This does not mean someone is literally in handcuffs. It means the past has power over the person. Family history, reputation, old promises or old mistakes can feel as if they are holding the character's wrists.

**The task**

Make an invisible pressure feel physical. Do not write only 'he felt trapped'. Show what is trapping him.

**Model answer**

Mina walked into school with her father's unfinished promise dragging at her ankles.

**Why it works**

The sentence turns a promise into something heavy that follows the body. We can feel the pressure before we know the whole story.

**Now you try**

Write one sentence about a child who feels trapped by family expectation, a promise, a rumour or an old mistake.

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## 2. Rushdie: a whole world inside one person

### *"swallow a world"*

Salman Rushdie, *Midnight's Children* (1981)

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| <b>Plain English</b> | The phrase suggests that one person can contain a huge amount: memories, places, languages, loyalties, fears and secrets. To understand the person, you almost have to enter the world inside them. |
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| <b>The task</b> | Show that a character is complicated by giving them a hidden inner world. |
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| <b>Model answer</b> | To understand Leila, you had to cross the city she carried inside: the bakery smell, the shouting buses, the sea wind she missed. |
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| <b>Why it works</b> | The answer avoids saying 'Leila was complicated'. It gives details that make her inner life visible. |
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#### Now you try

Write three sentences beginning with: To understand him/her, you had to...

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### 3. Rushdie: make an abstract force physical

#### *"optimism as a disease"*

Salman Rushdie, *Midnight's Children* (1981)

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| <b>Plain English</b> | Rushdie often makes large ideas feel bodily. Instead of leaving words like guilt, pride or history floating in the air, he gives them weight, force and action. |
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| <b>The task</b> | Choose one abstract noun and make it do something physical to a character. |
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| <b>Model answer</b> | Guilt pressed its thumb into Josh's throat whenever the teacher asked who had broken the window. |
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| <b>Why it works</b> | Guilt becomes a hand. The pressure in the throat also shows why Josh cannot speak easily. |
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#### **Now you try**

Write four sentences. Use one of these nouns: guilt, pride, jealousy, ambition, homesickness, duty.

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#### 4. Rushdie: stories as water

### *"Ocean of the Streams of Story"*

Salman Rushdie, *Haroun and the Sea of Stories* (1990)

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| <b>Plain English</b> | Rushdie imagines stories as moving water. That makes stories feel alive: they can flow, mix, change direction and carry people away. |
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| <b>The task</b> | Turn an abstract thing into a place or natural force. |
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| <b>Model answer</b> | The rumour became a river by lunchtime, slipping under every classroom door. |
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| <b>Why it works</b> | A rumour is invisible, but the river image gives it movement. It spreads without needing legs. |
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#### **Now you try**

Write three sentences where a rumour, secret, memory or idea behaves like water.

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## 5. Rushdie: make writing feel alive

### *"not dead, but alive"*

Salman Rushdie, *Haroun and the Sea of Stories* (1990)

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| <b>Plain English</b> | This phrase is simple, but the idea is powerful. A story is not a fixed object. It can move, change and answer back. |
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| <b>The task</b> | Make a story, memory, silence or secret behave like a living thing. |
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| <b>Model answer</b> | The secret twitched whenever Ella's mother said his name. |
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| <b>Why it works</b> | The secret is treated like a small living creature. That makes the silence feel nervous. |
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#### Now you try

Write four sentences where an abstract thing behaves as if it is alive.

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## 6. Roy: weather with a mood

### *"hot, brooding month"*

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

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| <b>Plain English</b> | A month cannot literally brood. Roy gives the weather a human mood, so the place feels tense before anything happens. |
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| <b>The task</b> | Let the weather suggest emotion before the characters explain anything. |
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| <b>Model answer</b> | The afternoon was airless and watchful; even the curtains seemed to be waiting for the argument. |
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| <b>Why it works</b> | The sentence makes the room feel tense without saying 'everyone was tense'. The weather prepares the reader. |
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#### Now you try

Describe the weather before an exam, an argument or a secret being revealed.

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## 7. Roy: one day can change everything

### *"Things can change in a day"*

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

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| <b>Plain English</b> | This is a sentence about sudden change. It teaches a useful story move: one ordinary day can become the day after which nothing is the same. |
| <b>The task</b>      | Make a normal day feel as if it is about to tilt.                                                                                            |
| <b>Model answer</b>  | By four o'clock, the Tuesday that had begun with burnt toast had split the family in two.                                                    |
| <b>Why it works</b>  | The sentence starts with ordinary detail, then turns sharply. That contrast makes the change feel dramatic.                                  |

#### Now you try

Write three sentences where an ordinary day becomes important.

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## 8. Roy: unsaid thoughts

### *"Big Things lurk unsaid inside"*

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

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| <b>Plain English</b> | The sentence makes silence feel crowded. Important thoughts are not spoken, but they are still present, hiding inside people. |
| <b>The task</b>      | Show what a character is not saying.                                                                                          |
| <b>Model answer</b>  | At dinner, Nora asked for salt, passed the bread, and kept the apology locked behind her teeth.                               |
| <b>Why it works</b>  | The ordinary actions cover the important feeling. The locked apology shows what is being held back.                           |

#### **Now you try**

Write four sentences where someone says something small while hiding something important.

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## 9. Roy: objects after disaster

### *"bleached bones of a story"*

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

**Plain English**

Roy makes the remains of an event feel like bones. Small objects can become evidence of a much bigger story.

**The task**

Use ordinary objects to suggest something serious has happened.

**Model answer**

On the desk lay a snapped pencil, a wet sleeve and the birthday card nobody had signed.

**Why it works**

The objects do not explain everything. They invite the reader to work out what might have happened.

**Now you try**

List three objects after an argument, then turn them into one sentence.

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## 10. Roy: a body-shaped adverb

*"fatly baffled in the sun"*

Arundhati Roy, *The God of Small Things* (1997)

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| <b>Plain English</b> | The adverb makes confusion look physical. The aim is normal English, chosen well: pick an adverb that changes the body's shape or posture. |
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| <b>The task</b> | Show a feeling through how the character stands, moves or speaks. |
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| <b>Model answer</b> | He stood stiffly cheerful in the doorway, smiling too hard at everyone. |
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| <b>Why it works</b> | The word 'stiffly' shows the smile is not relaxed. The reader senses discomfort without being told exactly what he feels. |
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### Now you try

Write four sentences using normal adverbs such as stiffly, heavily, sharply, awkwardly, proudly, slowly or weakly.

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## 11. Roy: setting as warning

**Plain English** Roy often lets the place know something before the people say it. A room, a window, a fan or a glass can make the scene feel uneasy.

**The task** Describe a place five minutes before bad news arrives. Do not mention the bad news yet.

**Model answer** The kitchen fan clicked above the table. A glass of water trembled each time the washing machine turned, though nobody touched it.

**Why it works** The objects are ordinary, but they feel slightly wrong. The reader expects something to happen.

### Now you try

Write a short room description before bad news, an apology or a secret.

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## 12. Mixed drill: pressure and atmosphere

**Plain English** This exercise combines the two moves. First make the setting carry emotion. Then make an invisible pressure act on the character.

**The task** Write two sentences: one atmosphere sentence, then one pressure metaphor.

**Model answer** The corridor smelled of raincoats and metal radiators, and the lights buzzed as if they knew. Adam's promise to his mother sat in his pocket like a stone.

**Why it works** The first sentence creates atmosphere. The second gives pressure a physical object, a stone in the pocket.

### Now you try

Write your own two-sentence version. Do not copy the model.

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### 13. Mixed drill: silence and objects

**Plain English** This exercise combines Roy's silence move with her object move. A character says something small, while the room quietly shows the larger trouble.

**The task** Write two sentences: one small spoken sentence, then one sentence about objects in the room.

**Model answer** "Lovely weather," Dad said. On the table, Mum's untouched tea had gone grey at the edges.

**Why it works** The spoken line is deliberately ordinary. The tea carries the real feeling.

#### Now you try

Write your own two-sentence version. Keep the spoken words small.

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## 14. Final writing challenge

**Plain English**

For a longer answer, do not try to sound clever in every sentence. Use two strong images, then let the scene move.

**The task**

Choose one: new school with a family secret, silent family dinner, a day that changes everything, or meeting someone who seems to carry another place inside them.

**Model answer**

The dining room was too warm, and the windows had gone black with evening. Sami's lie sat between the plates, small and hard, waiting for someone to pick it up.

**Why it works**

The room creates tension first. The lie becomes a hard object on the table. The image is simple enough to understand but strong enough to remember.

**Now you try**

Write the opening six to eight lines of your chosen scene.

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